



Ages 11 to 14

Friendships, Relationships and Control

How to spot when a friendship or relationship has become controlling, and what you can do.
For all students.

Before You Read This guide talks about controlling friendships and relationships.

This guide is about friendships and relationships where one person tries to control another. Some of it might feel close to home. That's OK.

- Read it in bits, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline** is free and confidential. You can call 0800 1111 any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.

If you or someone else is in danger right now, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

Good friendships and relationships make you feel safe, free and like yourself. This guide helps you spot when a friendship or relationship has become **controlling**, and what you can do about it.

- It can happen between **friends**, in a **friendship group**, or between people who are **going out**.
- It can happen to **anyone**: girls and boys, and people of any background or sexuality.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust**: a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.

- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free, any time.

What Do the Words Mean?

Healthy

You feel safe, you can be yourself, and you can have other friends and say no without being scared.

Controlling

When someone tries to decide what you do, who you see, what you wear or who you message.

Coercive control

A pattern of controlling behaviour that makes someone feel scared, alone or like they can't say no.

Pressure

Being pushed, guilt-tripped or scared into doing something you don't want to do.

Trusted adult

An adult you feel safe with: a teacher, tutor, coach, house parent, counsellor or family member.

Healthy or Controlling?

Healthy

- You can have other friends, and they're happy for you
- You can wear what you like and do things you enjoy
- Your phone and messages are yours
- You can disagree or say no without being scared
- You feel good about yourself when you're with them

Controlling

- They tell you who you can and can't talk to or sit with
- They get angry or upset if you spend time with other people
- They check your phone, or want your passwords
- They make "rules" about what you wear or do
- You feel nervous about how they'll react

Everyone gets jealous or has fall-outs sometimes. Control is different: it's a **pattern** that keeps happening and makes you feel smaller, not safer. **But you don't have to wait for it to happen again before you tell an adult.**

What It Can Look Like

In Person

- "If you're friends with her, you can't be friends with me"
- Warning other people not to talk to you
- Deciding where you sit, what clubs you go to, or what you wear
- Spreading rumours about people who stay friends with you

Online

- Lots of messages, and getting angry if you don't reply straight away
- Wanting to see your messages, or know your passwords
- Making you share your location all the time
- Threatening to share something private about you

How It Can Feel

- Like you're walking on eggshells, or always worried about getting it wrong
- Confused, because they can be really nice as well
- Scared of losing them, especially if they're your closest friend
- Lonely, because you've stopped seeing other friends
- Like it's your fault. **It isn't.**

If you feel like this, it's worth talking to someone. You don't need to be sure it's "bad enough".

Staying Safe Online

- **Your phone is yours.** Real friends don't need your passwords or to read your messages.
- Think carefully before sharing your location, and check who can see it.
- If someone threatens to share a picture or a secret, **don't send anything, don't pay, and tell an adult.** It isn't your fault.
- **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation) can help get a nude image of you removed if you are under 18.
- Don't make big changes to your phone on your own if you're scared of how someone will react. An adult can help you plan.

RESPOND: What You Can Do

Young people often tell a friend first. That makes you important. Here is what you can do if you are worried about a friend.

You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Is your friend being told who they can see, or what to wear?
- Have they stopped doing things they used to love, or seem nervous about their phone?
- You don't need to be sure to do something

E

Engage

Talk and listen.

- Find a quiet moment: "You don't seem yourself. Is everything OK?"
- Listen. Don't ask lots of questions or tell them they're silly
- **If you see it happening, and it is safe to do so**, you can help: ask your friend to come with you, change the subject, or get an adult



Support

Be there.

- "It's not your fault. I'm here for you."
- Keep including them, even if they've pulled away

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Stop and think.

- Don't try to sort it out yourself, and don't confront the other person
- Don't promise to keep it a secret if someone could be hurt
- You don't have to find out more, keep watch or collect proof. Sorting it out is the adults' job

Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Show them there's help.

- Tell your friend a trusted adult can help, and offer to go with them
- Be the kind of friend who lets people be themselves



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- If you're worried, tell a trusted adult, **even if your friend asks you not to**. Tell your friend you're going to, if you can
- That isn't getting them into trouble. It's how they get help



Document

Adults write it down.

- The adult will make a record. You just need to tell them what you saw and heard

If It's Happening to You

You Are Not to Blame

- It's not your fault. Nobody deserves to be controlled.
- You don't have to deal with it on your own, and you don't have to be sure it's "bad enough".
- You can tell any adult you trust. If the first person doesn't help, tell someone else.

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with someone you trust.** Behind them is a team whose job is to make sure you get the right help.
- The adult will listen and take what you say seriously.
- They won't go and have a go at the other person. They'll make a plan with the school's safeguarding team to keep you safe.
- If an adult is worried about your safety, they will share the concern with the school's safeguarding team. They will explain what happens next and involve you as much as possible in decisions about keeping you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret.
- Adults who work with young people are allowed to share information that helps keep children safe without asking your permission. They only share what is needed, and only with the people who need to know. They will tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put someone in danger, and they will listen to what you think.
- You will be kept informed and asked what you need.

Whoever You Are

- Controlling behaviour can happen in any friendship or relationship, including same-sex ones. Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111.
- No one should control you because of "rules" about culture, religion or family honour. If you're worried about this, talk to a trusted adult.
- If you find it hard to tell when something isn't OK, that's fine: ask an adult you trust.

If You're Worried About How You Treat Others

Sometimes people control others because they feel worried, jealous or scared of being left out. If you think you might be doing some of the things in this guide, that takes courage to notice. People can change.

- Talk to an adult you trust at school.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"Jealousy shows they really care"	Caring means wanting you to be happy, including with other friends. Control isn't care.
"It only happens between people going out"	It can happen between friends and in friendship groups too.
"Only girls get controlled"	Anyone can be controlled, including boys.
"If they're nice sometimes, it's not controlling"	Controlling people are often nice as well. That's part of what makes it confusing.
"Telling an adult will make it worse"	Adults will make a plan with you to keep you safe, and tell you what's happening.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If someone in your house is controlling you, or you're worried about a friend, tell a house parent, even in the evening.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.

- You can always contact your family privately.



Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19)**: 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- **Shout**: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Love Respect (Women's Aid)**: loverspect.co.uk, information and a relationship quiz for young people
- **Emergency**: call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Friendships, Relationships and Control: Student Guide 46 - 11 to 14

© 2026/27 | **RESPOND** Safeguarding Framework

Contacts and figures checked September 2026 | Next review: September 2027